hierarchy probably inhered in the designation of Qutb al-Din as *malik al-jibal* – a grandiose title implying the designee's importance.[60] But at the same time, Qutb al-Din was 'Izz al-Din's second son, not his first and eldest, and neither he nor the eldest, Fakhr al-Din Mas'ud, were born to "the mother of the other Sultans." Further, it is unclear whether Qutb al-Din appropriated the title *himself* or, if not, why and when exactly it was bestowed upon him. It is not impossible that the somewhat steadier, commercially derived prosperity of Jam-Firuzkuh (see Chapter 2) enriched and emboldened Qutb al-Din to adopt the title. Such an emphatic self-elevation could justifiably have resulted from his otherwise secondary status as the son of a mother from a lesser pedigree.[61]

The situation was similar with the Shansabani lineage of Bamiyan, whose scions had come into possession of a region probably even more prosperous than Firuzkuh, thanks to its centuries-long centrality within commercial and pilgrimage networks (cf. Chapter 3). Several decades before Juzjani recorded the Firuzkuh rulers' concession of the title of *sultan* to their Bamiyan cousins in AH 586/1190 CE, coins minted during the reign of Fakhr al-Din Mas'ud (AH 540–558/1145–63 CE) at the elusive site of Parwan/Farwan, somewhere north of Kabul, claimed the title of *al-sultan al-'azam* for him.[62] Furthermore, Juzjani reported that as the eldest, Fakhr al-Din was not satisfied with his appanage of Bamiyan and, toward the end of his reign, unsuccessfully attempted the usurpation of Jam-Firuzkuh from his nephews Shams al-Din and Shihab al-Din – later Sultan Ghiyath al-Din (d. AH 599/1203 CE) and Sultan Mu'izz al-Din (d. AH 602/1206 CE), respectively.[63] From this admittedly fragmentary evidence, it could nonetheless be ventured that Juzjani, in keeping with the "historiographic expectations" of his time, attempted to salvage for posterity a Firuzkuh-centered Shansabani dynasty from what was in reality a periodic confederacy of disparate lineages. Often bitterly contentious in their own time, the author elected instead to portray the Shansabanis in a generally unitary light.[64] Thus, the actual impetuses and contingencies behind the reported events, along with their protagonists, are often to be discerned in non-textual historical indices.

The unforeseen and successive deaths of the first three *malik*s of Jam-Firuzkuh thrust to the forefront the dynamism of 'Izz al-Din's fifth son, 'Ala' al-Din Husain (r. AH 544–556/1150–1161 CE). Motivated by his brother Qutb al-Din's death at the Ghazna court of Bahram Shah (r. AH 512–547/1118–1152 CE) – even though a quarrel between Qutb al-Din and his brothers drove him thence in the first place – Saif al-Din "brought an army to Ghazna and captured it … and the first person of this clan to take the title of Sultan was Sultan Suri." Bahram Shah returned to Ghazna, however, and executed Saif al-Din and his advisors in a most humiliating way. In turn, Baha' al-Din died of "excessive anxiety and grief for the death of his brothers" while he was en route to Ghazna to exact vengeance.[65]